

Validate Keywords With Three Weeks of Google Ads

The play: **Gert Mellak**, SEOLeverage · heard on The Unscripted SEO Interview Podcast with Jeremy Rivera

SETUP

~2 hours

TEST WINDOW

3 weeks

READ-OUT

~1 hour

INPUTS

3 keywords, ad budget, landing page

OBJECTIVE

Replace a keyword argument with a three-week purchase test. You end up with two numbers a search volume tool cannot give you: how many people really typed the exact query in your market, and how many of them converted after landing on your page. Those two numbers decide whether the SEO project gets built on those keywords or on different ones.

KEY STEPS

1. **Ask the client to name the three keywords they believe will make or break the business.** Their three, not yours. Writing them down is what makes the test binding later.
2. **Write down what each side expects, before the ads run.** Tool search volume per keyword, plus the client's expected conversion count. This is the prediction the test is scored against.
3. **Pause the SEO project on those keywords.** Do not build content on a term you are about to test. If the test kills it you have thrown the work away.
4. **Run Google Ads on exactly those three keywords, exact match, for three weeks.** No broad match, no expansion, no other terms in the campaign. Send clicks to the page you would have built the SEO around. (*inferred: exact match is what makes the measurement possible.*)
5. **Budget for enough clicks to read a zero.** A zero-conversion result only means something if enough people clicked. Pace the daily budget across the full three weeks. (*inferred: Gert names no budget figure.*)
6. **Change nothing else for three weeks.** No landing page edits, no offer changes, no other campaigns on the same page. The three weeks exist so people have time to decide.
7. **Read two numbers, not the whole report.** Real impressions and clicks vs. the tool's search volume, and conversions from people who typed the exact query. Everything else is noise for this decision.
8. **Apply the decision rule and restart the project on what survived.**

DECISION RULE. **Converts at acceptable cost** → the keyword is real, build the SEO on it. **Real click volume, zero conversions** → the keyword is not the business, drop it no matter what the volume column says. **Real volume far below the tool number** → recalculate the case on the true number, and keep it if the traffic still converts. Gert's 2,500-to-120 case survived on exactly that basis.

CAUTIONARY NOTES

- **This tests purchase intent, not your SEO.** An ad click and an organic click are not the same click. Use it to decide whether the demand exists, not to forecast organic traffic.
- **Broad match destroys the test.** Other queries in the campaign means you are no longer measuring the keyword the client named.
- **The tool's volume number is not the answer.** Search Console does not rescue it either: bots produce impressions and Google is not filtering them.
- **Three weeks is short for a long sales cycle.** If the buying decision takes two months, a zero-conversion result may be a timing artifact. Track soft conversions and key-page landings instead.
- **Do not run it as a gotcha.** It works because both sides agreed to the terms in step one. Run it as a shared question and the client owns the answer with you.
- **A surviving keyword is not a strategy.** It is one validated term.

TIPS FOR EFFICIENCY

- If the client already runs paid, skip the test and pull their converting-keyword report. The three-week test is for when nobody has the data.
- One campaign, three exact-match ad groups. Budget pacing and reporting stay in one place.
- Book the read-out meeting when you launch, three weeks out. It stops the test running quietly for two months.
- Save the before-and-after table: tool volume next to real volume, expected conversions next to actual, on one page.
- Feed the result back to the paid team either way.

"Pick the three keywords that you think are going to make or break your business, and run ads for them over three weeks. And then you come back, and then restart the SEO project." - Gert Mellak